

contemporary parallels. For instance, Duryodhana has envy and this is linked to Ambani versus Ambani. Draupadi's courage is interpreted as public accountability and this is linked to Pratibha Patil's election (despite corruption charges) and Bhishma-like Manmohan Singh's silence. Yudhishtira's duty is linked to corruption and travails of a CEO who refused to pay bribes. This is also where repeated play of prisoner's dilemma is brought in, though Yudhishtira hardly played repeated games. Arjuna's despair is linked to Saddam Hussein and Iraq. Bhishma's selflessness is linked to Sonia Gandhi. Karna's status anxiety is linked to reservations and positive affirmation. Krishna's guile is linked with Nuremberg trials, Amnesty International and so on. Ashwatthama's revenge is linked with Narendra Modi. The concluding chapter brings in Satyam and Wall Street. It has been said of the Mahabharata that what is not found in it is not found anywhere. That's largely because every conceivable human emotion figures in the epic. Consequently, since human emotions and human actions continue to be replicated, it is possible to construct contemporary parallels and some of these are innovative. Especially since Das writes well, the

Had Das restricted himself to India yesterday and discussed moral dilemmas in the Mahabharata, he would have produced an excellent volume.

book will be read because of these. However, I don't think the artifice has worked and it seems artificial.

Back to the dramatis personae. Duryodhana is more complicated than envy alone and he has a case. It is not Dhritarashtra alone who called him Suyodhana. If one considers geography (meaning kingdoms) of pre-Kurukshetra and post-Kurukshetra India, a case can be made out for man Krishna's (not god Vasudeva) actions being explained by territorial ambitions. The Yadavas were not allied to major empires and were driven out of Mathura by Jarasandha. Form alliances with the Pandavas through Kunti, Subhadra and Karenmat. Kill Shalva and Shishupala. Get Jarasandha killed by the Pandavas. Get them to form alliances with Drupada and Virata. Post-Kurukshetra, relatives of the Yadavas on the maternal side ruled both Hastinapura and Indraprastha. Karna's charity is much more interesting than his status anxiety. The point is characters chosen by Das are not as uni-dimensional as he makes them out to be. The concluding chapter states, "I find that I have been guilty in seeking a singular, coherent dharma in the epic." This could have been realised before 434 pages were written. Das quotes Wendy Doniger to the effect that reading Sanskrit is good for the soul. The book may have done that and fuelled his quest for *vanaprasthya* (sic). But I would prefer Das's sticking to *artha* (and perhaps *kama*) rather than dabble in dharma and *moksha*. ■

Ideal World

A young entrepreneur offers radical ideas for inclusive governance

By Dillip Bobb



MAKING INDIA WORK
by WILLIAM
NANDA BISSELL
Penguin/Viking
Price: Rs 499
Pages: 238

Fabindia is the successful retail chain that added the chic to ethnic. Founded by an American, every product carried a social message: promoting Indian craft traditions and rural employment. It's a corporate mantra that has led to 100 plus stores selling its signature range of handloom textiles, garments and organic products. We now have what can be called the Fabindia School of Economic Thought in the form of *Making India Work* by William Nanda Bissell, son of the late founder. Bissell's economic prescription comes laced

with a strong dose of idealism.

The book contains some radical ideas like Targeted Catalysts in which every BPL individual will receive credits to be used against essential services and service providers will be rated on performance. Also, a cashless economy based on smart cards that record every individual's gross income and expenditure, and money is transferred directly to the poor. He also proposes a National Exchange where assets and services like water, wheat, education etc are traded and regulated. In practical terms, it's a huge leap of imagination and execution.

Bissell covers the entire gamut of India's ills in his roadmap for inclusive, cooperative governance but it is far too utopian considering it strongly endorses the Panchayati Raj system and more power to the people, in this case, rural people, which entails the Central and state governments signing away many of their powers. His effort is backed with extensive research and statistical support but he does set his sights incredibly high in terms of the social, constitutional, legal and economic transformation it envisages. This book does highlight many of the problems crippling development from the vantage point of being one of the elite and yet rooted in rural India, an Indian and yet an outsider, an idealist and yet an entrepreneur. The solutions in this book may not be all that practical or even achievable but it is well worth the read just to get a feel of the passion, patriotism, missionary zeal and the assurance with which the author presents his arguments. This could well be called Fabindia 2.0. ■